Step 2 of 3 · Your business, today

Here is what I heard

Check each line. The quotes are Ayanda's own words. Anything marked as a default or a follow-up is one tap from changing.

KIND OF DECISION: ✓ Take on a big contract or order | Make a hire | Raise prices

Read from her words, in code

THE DECISION YOU
Take on a 12-month corporate lunch contract
You said: "Should I take the contract?"

THE BUSINESS YOU
Meal-prep and catering, Johannesburg
You said: "meal-prep and catering business"

SALES A MONTH RANGE
R75 000 – R105 000
Usually R90 000
You said: "about R90,000 a month, anywhere from R75k to R105k"

STOCK, INGREDIENTS AND PACKAGING YOU
R36 000
60% of sales left after these
You said: "Ingredients and packaging cost R36,000 a month"

RENT, POWER, FUEL AND SOFTWARE YOU
R16 000
Fixed every month
You said: "Rent, power, fuel and software come to R16,000"

STAFF WAGES FROM A FOLLOW-UP
R21 000
Asked once, as the only follow-up
You said: "21k"

WHAT YOU PAY YOURSELF YOU
R12 000
Counted as a cost on every path
You said: "I pay myself R12,000"

DEBT REPAYMENTS YOU
R3 500
The delivery van
You said: "We repay R3,500 a month on the delivery van"

CASH IN THE BUSINESS YOU
R120 000
Covers about 2 months of fixed costs
You said: "R120,000 in the business account"

NEW CONTRACT, A MONTH YOU
R60 000
Paid 60 days after each invoice
You said: "worth R60,000 a month"

DAYS THE CLIENT TAKES TO PAY YOU
60 days
Sets when the contract money lands
You said: "they pay 60 days after each invoice"

THE NEW PERSON, A MONTH YOU
R8 500
Needed to run the contract
You said: "another cook at R8,500 a month"

ONE-OFF COST TO START YOU
R25 000
Paid in month 1 on path B
You said: "a second fridge for R25,000"

COMFORT WITH RISK YOU
Low
Shapes how trade-offs are framed, never the numbers
You said: "I'm careful with risk"

WHAT MATTERS MOST YOU
cash safety, growth
Each future founder reflects on these
You said: "cash safety and growth"

placeholder Behind the three paths, not yet sourced: the contract's direct costs are 35–50% of its value; rented equipment costs 5% of its price a month; setback sizes come from the defaults file. Each is marked on the path pages.

Parallax

- Profile
- Paths
- Assumptions
- Compare
- Trace

Export JSON
Delete everything

Mockup 5 v2 · Control Room

A · Stay lean | B · Take it as offered | C · Take it on safer terms

Ayanda's decision: take a 12-month corporate lunch contract



AI-generated

YOU, AS THE FOUNDER, 36 MONTHS ON

B Take it as offered

Take the 12-month contract now, paid 60 days after each invoice.

All paths | Assumptions | Trace | Compare | Comfort check

When did cash get tightest?

Three years on, the contract changed the business. But the first stretch was the hardest I've had: I paid for food, a cook and the equipment long before the first payment landed, and cash got thinner than I ever want it again. Once the payments came in, it turned around fast.

BASED ON B6 · Contract income, paid 60 days after each invoice | B9 · Equipment for the contract, bought up front

Ask this on another path | Pin this quote

What would you warn me about?

If I could warn you about one thing, it's the gap between doing the work and being paid for it. Profit on paper didn't pay wages. If they had paid even later than agreed, I'm not sure we'd have made it.

BASED ON B6 · Contract income, paid 60 days after each invoice | B7 · Direct costs of the contract work

TRACE · THIS REPLY

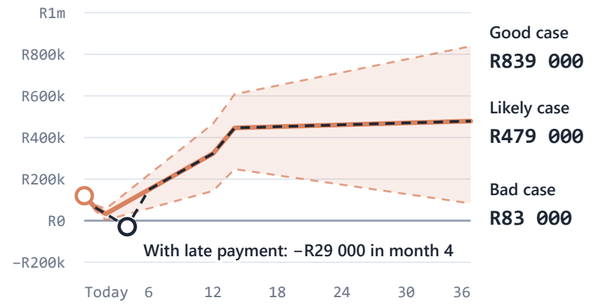
- ✓ Speaks in the first person, 36 months on
- ✓ Cites two assumptions, B6 and B7
- ✓ Does not tell her what to choose
- ✓ Figures come from code, not the model
- ✓ Names a downside: the gap between work and payment

Ask your future self... Send

Not financial advice · One possible future, not a prediction

Cash in the business, 36 months

Path B. Solid: the likely case. Dashed: the same case with a two-month late payment on the first contract invoice.



Month 36 bad R83 000 · likely R479 000 · good R839 000

Stress test on this path

One setback at a time, likely case. Sizes are placeholder except the client's own payment terms.

Late payment
a big client pays 2 months late, then catches up
−R29 000 · month 4 — Month 36: R479 000
runs out in month 4

Lost client
your biggest customer stops buying for 3 months
R33 000 · month 2 — Month 36: R430 400
stays above zero

Slow season
gross profit drops 33% for 2 months
R33 000 · month 2 — Month 36: R443 360
stays above zero

Equipment breakdown
one repair bill
R33 000 · month 2 — Month 36: R464 000
stays above zero

Cost rise
rent and running costs go up 10% from then on
R33 000 · month 2 — Month 36: R429 400
stays above zero

Three paths on one scale

Bars share one scale, from −R200 000 to R900 000; the dot is the likely case. A late payment is a big client paying two months late. Path A has no contract, so it applies to the biggest client's share of sales.

	A Stay lean	B Take it as offered	C Take it on safer terms
Cash at month 12, likely	**R138 000** Bad R30 000 · Good R246 000	**R323 000** Bad R143 000 · Good R467 000	**R393 000** Bad R213 000 · Good R537 000
Cash at month 36, likely	**R174 000** Bad −R150 000 · Good R498 000 	**R479 000** Bad R83 000 · Good R839 000 	**R489 000** Bad R93 000 · Good R849 000 
Lowest cash, likely	**R121 500** Month 1	**R33 000** Month 2	**R87 750** Month 1
Lowest cash with a 2-month late payment	**R98 100** Month 7 · stays above zero	**−R29 000** Month 4 · runs out in month 4	**R23 250** Month 3 · stays above zero
Cash runs out, bad case	**Month 17** Only in the bad case	**Never** No case runs out	**Never** No case runs out
Three months of fixed costs covered	**Month 25** Likely case	**Month 8** Likely case	**Month 5** Likely case
Worst setback, likely case	**Lost client** Lowest cash R83 400, month 8	**Late payment** Lowest cash −R29 000, month 4	**Late payment** Lowest cash R23 250, month 3
The plan	*Turn the contract down and keep running the business as it is.*	*Take the 12-month contract now, paid 60 days after each invoice.*	*Take it only if the client pays within 30 days, and rent the equipment instead of buying it.*

COMFORT CHECK

How does each future sit with you?

These ratings are an example of the check, not a real rating. 1 is very uneasy, 5 is at peace.



A Stay lean

1 2 **3** 4 5



B Take it as offered

1 **2** 3 4 5



C Take it on safer terms

1 2 3 **4** 5

WHAT IS STILL BOTHERING YOU?

Whether the client will really pay on 30-day terms. example

DECISION MEMO · PRINTED FROM PARALLAX

Take on the 12-month corporate lunch contract?

CHOICE **Not chosen yet.** Ayanda picks a path, or "Not ready yet", before this prints. Parallax never names a choice she has not made.

The three paths, 36 months of cash in the business

PATH	MONTH 36, BAD	MONTH 36, LIKELY	MONTH 36, GOOD	LOWEST, LIKELY	LOWEST, 2-MONTH LATE PAYMENT
 **A Stay lean** Turn the contract down and keep running the business as it is.	−R150 000	R174 000	R498 000	R121 500 month 1	R98 100 month 7
 **B Take it as offered** Take the 12-month contract now, paid 60 days after each invoice.	R83 000	R479 000	R839 000	R33 000 month 2	−R29 000 month 4 · runs out
 **C Take it on safer terms** Take it only if the client pays within 30 days, and rent the equipment instead of buying it.	R93 000	R489 000	R849 000	R87 750 month 1	R23 250 month 3

The setback to watch

Late payment. If the client pays two months late on the first invoice, path B falls to **−R29 000** in month 4 and runs out of cash. Path C bottoms at **R23 250** in month 3 and stays above zero.

What the numbers rest on

- Sales R75 000 to R105 000 a month, usually R90 000 — you
- Staff wages R21 000 a month — from a follow-up
- The client pays 60 days after each invoice — you
- Contract direct costs 35–50% of its value — placeholder
- Rented equipment 5% of its price a month — placeholder
- Setback sizes — placeholder

Open questions and checks in real life

- Will the client agree to 30-day terms? — example
- What does a fridge cost to rent, compared with buying? — example
- Ask the client for 30-day payment terms before signing. — example

Avatars are AI-generated illustrations (Muse Image). A reflection aid, not financial advice. One possible future, not a prediction.